

beg to differ. In fact, they believe Indian engineers come with strong conceptual understanding and impressive learning aptitude. They need to be trained only on the latest tools and development methodologies as they're not usually exposed to these at the college level. However, they're able to pick up everything they need pretty quickly.

When working on projects for designing low power chips, efficient multi-core architectures, mixed signal chips, memory sub-systems, interrupt controllers, and interfacing with video/audio processor, the basic textbook knowledge may be insufficient.

"Current curriculum touches the basics of computer architecture, while taking up a school project and learning the relevant design automation tools, from companies like Cadence/Mentor Graphics/Synopsys will be a practical help," said Sandeep.

Some companies have strong mentorship programmes whereby junior engineers are paired with a senior engineer who coaches and guides them along their way. This is, of course, in addition to regular training programmes.

Work culture

It's not all work and no play when it comes to a career in chip designing. It's a very young industry to work in and the average age of employees at most companies is low, making the work culture active and vibrant. Companies have extremely challenging programmes which motivate teams to deliver; but at the same time, there are several recreational activities such as team building, sports and quarterlies. Intel organises events such as cricket sessions and tennis matches that involve employees as well as their families. So it's a mixture of cutting edge work and fun.

Career path

Career paths in this industry are well defined for aspirants in both, technical and management functions. Typically, an engineer takes about 5-6 years to reach the position of a Senior Design Engineer. As the aspirant gains more work experience by working with different designs, he can advance to a Lead position. Post this level, the engineer can decide if he wants to continue in the technical function or move to a management function such as Project Manager, both of which are equally fulfilling depending on the inclination. How quickly you grow depends entirely on your individual ability. You can also branch off and choose to become